



the number of complaints against hospitals has zoomed up."

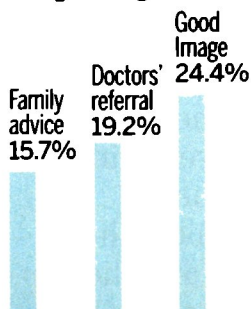
The world of hospital caring is changing fast for the consumer. A maddening tooth-ache on a Sunday morning had forced Sandhya Negi of Patparganj in Delhi to step into the snazzy neighbourhood hospital. She wasn't destined to burn a hole in her pocket. The doctor couldn't be traced. The hospital apologised, but it was the phone call later in the day that took her breath away. "I'm doctor X," crooned a voice, "Sorry for not being there. Hope you won't hold it against us." A far cry from her trip to a well-known government hospital some years back. She still remembers the agonisingly long wait and patients swarming around a harassed doctor. Would she go back to that hospital now that she has more choice?

That line of patient-thinking is reflected in the survey in hand: the top reason for choosing a superspeciality or tertiary hospital is good reputation and image, followed by referral from a doctor and recommendation by close friends and family. "The new-age consumer—more sensitive about matters concerning health, more willing to spend on the best possible service and more keen to get value for money, is asserting his choice," says Dr Naresh Trehan, the man who had set up the Escorts Heart Institute & Research Centre in Delhi on his return to India from the US two decades back. Not surprisingly, "referred by doctor" is the top reason in districts, among the less educated and economically weaker.

"There is persuasive evidence that quality of care influences hospital demand," write two US economists, Dana Goldman and John Radley, in their December 2008 study, 'Hospitals as hotels: the role of patient amenities in hospital demand'. While a one-standard-deviation increase in amenities ("such as good food, attentive staff, and pleasant surroundings") raised a hospital's demand by 38.4 per cent on average, the demand was substantially less responsive to clinical quality.

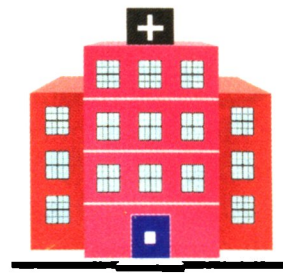
CHECKING IN

Why did you choose the hospital?



13.5%

Chose hospitals managed by professional doctors



Graphics by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

doctors recommend

1. Wockhardt, Cunningham Rd, Bangalore
2. Manipal, Bangalore
3. Apollo, Chennai
4. AIIMS, Delhi
5. Rockland Hospital, Delhi

How long did the registration process take?



* All figures in minutes

fastest front desk*

1. AMRI, Salt Lake, Kolkata, 8.43
2. Wockhardt Mulund, Mumbai 9.10
3. Escorts Hospital, Delhi 9.96
4. Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai 10.58
5. Apollo Hospital, Chennai 11.09

Average time taken for registration at all superspecialities **22.4** minutes

AMRI, Kolkata, took the least time **8.43** minutes

All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Delhi, the most **74** minutes

In the survey in hand, too, hospitals that topped in "overall satisfaction" were those that offered more amenities. From cleanliness to parking, clear signage to wheelchairs—Apollo, Chennai, and Wockhardt, Bangalore, met most of the standards. At Manipal Hospital, Bangalore, a greater proportion of respondents had used the emergency; Wockhardt, Bangalore won top ratings for easy accessibility, round the clock service, equipment, and helpful nurses. Escorts Hospital, Delhi, and Apollo, Chennai, scored on

registration—counter and form, efficient staff, sitting arrangement to time taken. Manipal, Apollo, Chennai, and Care Banjara, Hyderabad, fared best in nursing staff—courtesy, flexibility and attitude.

Going by the same logic, the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Delhi (AIIMS), despite its reputation, did not fare well. Staggering under patient overload, the average time taken to get registered here works out to 74 minutes, while the average in superspeciality and tertiary hospitals is 22.4 minutes. Ask Dr K.S.